SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #115 · GRACE & WORKS

“I have to clean up my life before I can come to God.”

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Where it often comes from

Feeling too ashamed or messy to approach God. Church cultures where people seemed to have it all together. Believing God only welcomes the good. Trying and failing to fix yourself first. Fear of rejection by God or His people.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus came for sinners, not for people who already have it all together. While we were still powerless, Christ died for the ungodly. The prodigal son came home in rags, and his father ran to embrace him before he could clean up. Jesus said, “Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened.” God invites you to reason with Him: though your sins are like scarlet, they will be as white as snow. You come as you are, and He does the cleaning.

> *“So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him”* **(Luke 15:20)**.

Also see

> “For at just the right time, while we were still powerless, Christ died for the ungodly” **(Romans 5:6)**.

> “Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest” **(Matthew 11:28)**.

> “‘Come now, let us reason together,’ says the LORD. ‘Though your sins are like scarlet, they will be as white as snow; though they are as red as crimson, they will become like wool.’” **(Isaiah 1:18)**.

> “If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness” **(1 John 1:9)**.

Common self-statements

- I need to get my life together first.
- God won’t accept me as I am.
- Once I stop this habit, I’ll come back to God.
- I’m too messy for church.
- I have to earn my way back.
- God only wants people who have it together.

Common logical errors

- **Reversing the order:** Believing change must come before coming to God, instead of through Him.
- **Labeling:** Calling yourself too messy or too far gone.
- **Fear-based thinking:** Staying away from God out of fear of rejection.
- **Self-reliance:** Trying to fix yourself before letting God help.

Challenging questions

- What did the father do before the prodigal could clean up?

- When did Christ die for the ungodly?
- Who does Jesus invite to come to Him?
- Can I clean myself up without God's help?
- What does Isaiah 1:18 say God will do with my sins?
- Am I waiting for something God never asked me to do first?
- What would it look like to come to God as I am today?

Truth summary

> I do not have to clean up my life before I can come to God. Jesus came for sinners. The Father runs to meet me as I am. I come with my mess, and He forgives and cleanses me. Change follows coming to God; it is not the price of admission.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grace
- Salvation
- Repent
- Mercy
- Forgiveness

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I have to clean up my life before I can come to God"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have to clean up my life before I can come to God." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did the father do before the son cleaned up?
- ☐ When did Christ die for the ungodly?
- ☐ Who does Jesus invite?
- ☐ Can I clean myself up without God?
- ☐ What will God do with my sins?
- ☐ What would coming as I am look like today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I can come to God as I am.
- ☐ The Father runs to meet me.
- ☐ Christ died for me while I was powerless.
- ☐ God cleanses me; I don't clean myself.
- ☐ Change follows coming to God.
- ☐ Jesus invites all who are weary and burdened.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Luke 15:20**
  "So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him."
- [ ] **Romans 5:6**
  "For at just the right time, while we were still powerless, Christ died for the ungodly."
- [ ] **Matthew 11:28**
  "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest."
- [ ] **Isaiah 1:18**
  "'Come now, let us reason together,' says the LORD. 'Though your sins are like scarlet, they will be as white as snow; though they are as red as crimson, they will become like wool.'"
- [ ] **1 John 1:9**
  "If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Come as I am log:** Each day, write one honest thing I brought to God without cleaning it up first.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Luke 15:20 becomes: "So **Sarah** got up and went to **her** Father. But while **she** was still in the distance, **her** Father saw **her** and was filled with compassion. He ran to **her**, embraced **her**, and kissed **her**."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Pray today exactly as you are,** telling God honestly about your mess.
- ☐ **Read Luke 15:11–24,** and write what the son had planned to say and what the father did instead.
- ☐ **Go to church or call a believer this week** before you feel "ready."
- ☐ **Ask God for help with one area of change,** trusting Him to do the work with you.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have to clean up my life before I can come to God": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One thing I brought to God as I am
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have to clean up my life before I can come to God.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that I can come to You just as I am. Help me reject the lie that I have to clean up my life first. I come to You with my mess, trusting You to forgive me, cleanse me, and change me from the inside. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.